stopped them. It would have reminded people of the awesome threat of those days and the terrible price in lives. It reminded me of something else. At that time, I was a member of the Israeli Pugwash group, a branch of an international organization (named after a small Canadian town) established in the 1950s by Bertrand Russell and Albert Einstein, at the height of the Cold War, to allow for informal contacts between American and Soviet academics in the search for dialogue openings, with the tacit knowledge of their respective governments.

In May 1973, Bill Polk, a member of the US Pugwash group and director of the Adlai Stevenson Institute in Chicago, phoned me in Jerusalem and invited me to a very confidential meeting with a Palestinian delegate, plus the usual American, Soviet, and Egyptian members of the group. The participation of a Palestinian was a first. Of course I agreed, but mentioned that I had to inform the prime minister's office and receive authorization. I called Mordechai Gazit, the director of Golda Meir's office. In my mind, this was a great opportunity to meet a Palestinian representative. Within minutes Gazit called me back: "The prime minister wants to see you." When? "Now."

I had never met the "old lady," a chain-smoking, Milwaukee-raised Zionist of a generation that knew no nuances and no compromises, "the only man in the Cabinet," Ben-Gurion said about her when she was labor minister. She became prime minister at Levi Eshkol's death in 1969 and led the Alignment (Mapai and Mapam) to its greatest electoral victory later that same year. She was tough on the Israeli "Black Panthers" (Mizrahi activists) and on everybody else.

"Shaul," she addressed me, although we had never met, "I forbid you to participate in that meeting in Chicago if a Palestinian is present. There is no Palestinian people. We were all Palestinians under the British mandate; I had a Palestinian passport. The so-called Palestinians are Arabs from Syria who came here during the mandate. You understand me?" I left, rather